Unveiled: A Stepparent's Journey Through Parental Alienation

Foreword

I always believed family was unshakable, until I realized that loyalty, love, and trust can be tested in ways no parent is ever prepared for.

My husband and I have two boys together, and he has two sons from a previous marriage. We both come from families who instilled in us values, morals, and a deep sense of belonging, principles that have become the foundation of our marriage and our parenting. Our lives are rich with traditions, celebrations, and the simple joys of family. From holidays and birthdays to vacations and everyday moments, we cherish the time spent together, honoring the past while creating new memories. This support system has truly been our lifeline over the past fourteen years, standing beside us as we continue to fight for our voice as parents amid the challenges we have faced.

I am not a clinician or a doctor. I am a teacher, a mom, and a stepparent who has been deeply involved in my stepchildren's lives since they were two and four years old. What follows is raw, emotional, and unfinished. Every experience I share is supported by fourteen years of well documented accounts through emails, texts, and conversations which became my lifeline amidst the chaos.

The research I reference comes from years of observation, reflection, and personal study, through books, podcasts, and articles. This is a personal memoir, grounded in my life experiences and reflections as a parent and stepparent. No names are used, and conversations are paraphrased or reconstructed from my memory and not quoted verbatim. The perspectives, feelings, and interpretations in this book are my own and offered in the spirit of truth, healing, and understanding. Certain details, timelines, and characteristics have been changed or blended to protect privacy. Any resemblance to actual persons or events is coincidental and unintentional beyond the author's own lived experience.

Above all, it is my attempt to illuminate what it feels like to watch loyalty, love, and family bonds shift under the pressure of manipulation, so that other parents and steparents may recognize the signs and act before it is too late.

Introduction:

We are still in the middle of it.

When I first discovered the term *parental alienation*, my life flashed before my eyes. Page after page, story after story. It wasn't just familiar, it was us. We were not just another blended family dealing with a messy situation, or struggling with different parenting styles. We were unquestionably dealing with parental alienation and our situation was textbook.

Every single example mirrored our reality. All of the feelings I had buried, questioned, or second-guessed were suddenly validated. I felt alive with the realization and satisfaction of being right! That "aha" moment you want to tell the world. However, that validation came like a crashing wave. *"How did we not see it? Why didn't counselors, the court, or anyone, call it what it was? Why did I have to claw through months of self-reflection, research, and podcasts before I found the name of what we were experiencing. Why was it only after my oldest stepson walked out the door for a normal week at his mom's to never return to our house again that we finally discovered truth?*

Our journey started fourteen years ago. Fourteen years of small erasures, strained exchanges, invisible battles, and heartbreaking shifts in the children we love. Fourteen years of trying to navigate a maze we didn't know had a map, and yet, our story is far from over. We still walk through it every day.

That is why I am writing this book. Other parents and stepparents deserve to know that what they are feeling is NOT "just in their head." That the knot in their stomach, the sense of being forgotten, the slow severing of connections they once had with their children, are not just feelings; they are real. Those gut feelings, could be signs of emotional abuse, not only directed at the targeted parent but also at the children themselves. If sharing my story brings awareness to even one child, if it helps even one family put words to what they are living, if it protects even one child from being weaponized, then I am one step further in saving myself, and maybe, saving others along the way.

This is not a story of resolution. It is a story of endurance. It is a story of truth told from one stepparent's perspective. One taken f*rom the outside, looking in*. This is a story that I hope sharing with you will allow you to feel less alone in your story.

Chapter 1: Walking Into the Middle: *The Early Signs*

I never expected that stepping into love would also mean stepping into a war I didn't start. When I met my husband, I knew he came with children and it didn't scare me. I am a teacher who works with kids every day, and I have seen wonderful examples of blended families. I pictured dinners around the table, shared holidays, maybe even the kind of chaos that feels like love. What I didn't picture was how invisible I could feel in a house full of people.

The first sign came before we were even married.

We were planning the wedding, and I was full of hope, dreaming about not just joining my life with my husband's, but also becoming part of his boys' lives. We had been living together for six months with his shared parenting visitation schedule, and we were learning the ins and outs of being a family. Two days before the wedding, my husband received a call from his ex-wife: *"I don't want the boys at your wedding. They are too young to choose if they want to be there, and it is unfair of you to put them in that situation at two and five years old."*

It was such an untimely call. Why wouldn't my husband's children, my future stepchildren, want to be part of our wedding? Why wouldn't they be part of their dad's joy, his family, his new beginning? I brushed it off at first, telling myself it was just stress, or nerves, or complicated co-parenting dynamics. But deep down, I felt the sting. It was the first time I realized someone else was already drawing lines around what role I was allowed to have in my stepchildren' s lives. It was seemingly a decision that was being forced upon me without any input from my husband, the children, or myself.

In the beginning, the boys were excited to see me. They would run through the door, full of stories, full of energy, happy to be together. But slowly over the years, that changed. The greetings faded. The warmth cooled. Soon, they'd walk right past me without a word, as if I were invisible in my own home. I'll never forget one moment with my oldest stepson. He looked me straight in the eyes and said, *"You're like a mom to us, because you do everything a mom does… but you're not a mom."*

I didn't know how to respond. In one sentence, he both acknowledged me, then, with a single phrase, removed me from existence. I wasn't asking to replace anyone, but I also couldn't deny what I felt: I was being written out of my own story before it had even begun. Even the word *stepmom* felt off-limits, as if using it would invite anger or rejection. I had no title, no name for my place, just the weight of doing everything: loving, caring, showing up, while being told, directly and indirectly, that I didn't matter.

Looking back, I see now that parental alienation doesn't start with shouting or accusations. It can start quietly. Whispers from a parent that fill a child's head with thoughts of exclusion, withholding recognition, and ultimately, starting the process of a slow erasure of your existence or importance. Before you know it, you are expected to fulfill a central role in the life of a family you desperately want to love, while remaining invisible. Unseen. Forgotten.

Chapter 2 –Parental Alienation

For years, I thought what we were living was just a "high conflict" co-parenting situation, or maybe just the unfortunate reality of divorce and blended families. But when I stumbled across the term Parental Alienation, and the clinical description of it, my heart stopped. We weren't living something unusual or unique. We were living something that had a name.

The Definition

Parental Alienation (often called PA) is a process in which one parent deliberately or unconsciously undermines and damages a child's relationship with the other parent. It goes far beyond occasional badmouthing or disagreements between adults. It is a consistent pattern of manipulation, distortion, and emotional conditioning designed intentionally or not, to make the child distance themselves, reject, or even despise the targeted parent. Psychiatrist Dr. Richard Gardner first introduced the term Parental Alienation Syndrome (PAS) in the 1980s to describe children who unjustifiably rejected one parent as a result of the other parent's influence. While the term "syndrome" is now less commonly used, the underlying behaviors and resulting emotional abuse remain central to how professionals understand and identify Parental Alienation today.

Modern researchers and clinicians describe PA as a form of psychological abuse that can profoundly affect a child's sense of safety, identity, and reality. The alienating parent often uses tactics such as exaggerating faults, rewriting history, fostering fear or guilt, controlling narratives, and rewarding rejection of the other parent. Over time, the child may internalize these distortions so completely that the rejection feels self-generated rather than influenced.

In short, Parental Alienation occurs when a child is pulled into a loyalty conflict so powerful that they begin to reject a loving and capable parent who has done nothing to warrant the loss. The tragedy lies in the fact that the child's belief in their own rejection feels entirely real, even though it has been carefully shaped by another's manipulation.

What It Looks Like

Alienation doesn't usually begin with dramatic outbursts. It creeps in slowly, almost invisibly, until one day you realize the child in front of you is no longer seeing you clearly, but through someone else's filter.

Here are some common signs: *keep in mind that these can be very subtle for years or escalate over time. Note cases will vary in severity.*

- **Badmouthing:** The child repeats criticisms of the targeted parent that are clearly adult in nature. ("Dad is irresponsible." "You don't take care of us.")

- **Erasure:** The child acts as if the targeted parent's contributions or care doesn't exist, even when they are daily and obvious.

- **Withholding affection:** What used to be hugs and excitement becomes silence, coldness, or refusal to engage.

- **Role reversal:** The child may take on the alienating parent's anger, becoming their "protector" and treating the targeted parent as the enemy.

- **Exclusion from milestones:** The alienating parent discourages or prevents the child from including the other parent in important events, birthdays, holidays, graduations etc.

- **Rigid loyalty:** The child shows an inability to see both parents as good. They "split," seeing one parent as all good, the other as all bad.

To an outsider, these behaviors can look like "teen rebellion" or "kids adjusting." But to those of us living it, the pattern is unmistakable. It is a systematic erasure, not natural distance.

What It Feels Like

Parental alienation is confusing because it targets both the child and the parent. The child feels pressure, guilt, and fear, taught that love is conditional. The targeted parent feels heartbreak, helplessness, and rage, watching their relationship dissolve while being told it's their fault.

For me, as a stepparent, the pain has been double-edged. I watch my husband be erased, and I also feel myself disappearing in the process. I was once greeted with joy, even called “like a mom.” But then the warmth froze. I became invisible. And no matter how much I gave, I was told, directly and indirectly, that I didn’t count.

Why Naming It Matters

When I first read the definition of parental alienation, my life clicked into place. Suddenly, what felt chaotic and personal had a pattern. We weren’t “crazy.” We were not imagining situations. This was a recognized form of emotional abuse. Naming it doesn’t fix it. It doesn’t make the alienation go away. But it does something almost as important, it validates your reality. It says, you are not imagining this. You are not alone. There is a name for what you are experiencing.

For any parent, or stepparent reading this, that knowledge is power, because the moment you name alienation, you stop blaming yourself. When you stop blaming yourself, you can begin the work of survival, and maybe even try to begin to heal and stay unbroken.

Signs You Might Be Experiencing Parental Alienation

Parental Alienation often creeps in gradually, making it hard to recognize at first. You may only start to see the pattern after repeated interactions leave you confused, hurt, or questioning your own reality. While every situation is different, here are common signs that may indicate you’re experiencing Parental Alienation:

- ☐ **Sudden, unexplained rejection:**
  Your child begins to pull away or show hostility without any clear reason or triggering event.

- ☐ **Rewriting of history:**
  Your child starts to recall past events inaccurately, exaggerating small mistakes or inventing new “wrongs” that never happened.

- ☐ **Loss of warmth and affection:**
  The child who once showed love, trust, and connection now seems cold, distant, or indifferent toward you.

- ☐ **One-sided loyalty:**
  Your child defends the other parent no matter what, while finding fault with everything you do, even neutral or positive actions.

- ☐ **Adult-like language or accusations:**
  Your child begins using words, tone, or ideas that sound more like the other parent's voice than their own.

- ☐ **Refusal of contact or visitation:**
  The child resists phone calls, visits, or time together and may say things like "I don't want to see you," without a clear reason or explanation.

- ☐ **Unfounded fear or guilt:**
  Your child expresses fear, anxiety, or guilt around spending time with you, even though there's no evidence of mistreatment or danger.

- ☐ **Rejection of extended family:**
  Your child also withdraws from your relatives, grandparents, cousins, or siblings acting as if they're part of the problem too.

- ☐ **Constant criticism:**
  Everything you say or do is met with sarcasm, suspicion, or contempt, while the other parent is idealized or "can do no wrong."

- ☐ **Lack of empathy for your feelings:**
  Your child seems unmoved by your pain or confusion, often echoing alienating narratives like "You deserve it" or "You never cared about me."

- ☐ **Coaching or scripting:**
  You notice your child repeating the same phrases, timing, or accusations in ways that feel rehearsed.

☐ **Conditional love:**
Your relationship with your child starts to feel transactional, based on whether you agree with, or act in alignment with, the alienating parent's agenda.

Ways that PA Shows up for Stepparents

Stepparents often find themselves caught in the crossfire of Parental Alienation without realizing it at first. While they may not be the direct target, they often feel the emotional and relational fallout. The alienating parent may weaponize the child's loyalty conflict to undermine not only the biological parent but also the new family unit. Here are some common ways PA can show up for stepparents:

☐ **Being treated as "the outsider."**
The alienating parent paints you as an intruder or replacement, convincing the child that your presence threatens their bond with the other parent. Even small gestures of care may be twisted as overstepping.

☐ **Disrespect or emotional withdrawal from the stepchild.**
The child may begin to mimic the alienating parent's dismissive or hostile attitude toward you, refusing to engage, avoiding eye contact, or being overtly rude.

☐ **Subtle exclusion from family relationships.**
The alienating parent may encourage the child to refer to "real" family versus "them," reinforcing the idea that you are temporary or unworthy of connection.

☐ **Rewriting your role.**
Your contributions, meals cooked, help with schoolwork, attending games may be minimized or reframed as controlling, manipulative, or unnecessary.

☐ **Triangulation through the child.**
The child is used to deliver hurtful messages or compare households ("Mom says

we don't have to do chores there," "Dad says you're strict"), keeping you and your spouse on the defensive.

- ☐ **Emotional distancing of your partner.**
  The stress of alienation can pull your spouse into guilt or conflict with you, especially if the child resists visits. You may feel pressure to stay silent or step back "for peace."

- ☐ **Being blamed for the alienation.**
  The alienating parent may accuse you of causing the child's rejection ("They liked me until you came along"), framing you as the wedge in the parent-child relationship.

- ☐ **Sudden changes in the child's comfort level.**
  A stepchild who once joked with you, accepted help, or sought comfort may suddenly become cold, distant, or angry and reflecting external influence, not genuine resentment.

- ☐ **Social or public exclusion.**
  The alienating parent might deliberately omit you from school events, communication loops, or celebrations, reinforcing to the child and others that you "don't belong."

- ☐ **Strain on your own sense of place.**
  You may begin to doubt your instincts, feel unseen in your own home, or question whether showing love will make things worse.

In essence:

Parental Alienation for stepparents is often a slow erasure of connection, of belonging, and of truth. You feel the chill of rejection that isn't truly yours to own. The goal of the alienating parent is not only to divide the child from their biological parent, but to fracture the entire sense of safety and unity in the blended family.

Chapter 3: When Time Stopped Being Ours: Early Signs of Control

In the beginning the changes were almost imperceptable and unnocticible at times. Looking back now, knowing what I know about parental alienation, I can see how quickly it all began to unravel. Small slights or isolated conflicts at the time were actually the earliest threads being pulled from our family fabric.

I had already heard the stories of my husband's life with his ex. The ups and downs. The qualities that had once seemed tolerable but ultimately left him unhappy. The constant control. The overbearing family influence. The onesided unfairness that bled into every corner of their marriage. He wanted more for himself, but most of all for his boys. He did not want them growing up in a home where being taken advantage of was mistaken for love, where silence passed as peace, and where respect was always one-sided.

When I came into his life, I carried an open mind. His experiences with his ex-wife hadn't happened to me. I wasn't the one who had lived through the manipulation or endured the slow grind of control. What I saw was a man standing in front of me who wanted to create a healthier life. Someone who believed his children deserved to grow up knowing fairness, love, and stability. Someone who wanted his children to learn that true love is respect and compromise, woven into the small, everyday choices of being a team. From the beginning, we promised ourselves we would co-parent with his ex, putting the boys first and offering good faith even when it wasn't returned. At the time, it felt like what adults do for the sake of their children. I realize now it was a vow rooted in hope and kept alive by endurance, even when it quietly broke us. The truth was, the unraveling had already begun, and the hill we started climbing would soon become Mt. Everest.

From my perspective as a stepparent, I often watched the strongest version of my husband; the steady, confident, and unwavering man, disappear the moment she asked or demanded something. In those moments, he became a shell of himself, giving in almost instantly. It frustrated me deeply because I could see so clearly what was happening. His ex-wife was using the same power and control she once held over him in their marriage, and he was still reacting as if he had to live with the consequences. I reminded him often, *"You don't live with her anymore, you don't have to brace for the fallout. We can stand our ground."* Despite all this we vowed to remain flexible and to not lose sight of what was important, which was the kids.

At first, the worst of it seemed to be the constant micromanaging of our home. Small interruptions, subtle scheduling tricks. She would plan events on our days or suddenly "remember" an obligation that required her to pick up the boys mid-visit. More often than not, it was a family birthday party that just happened to fall on my husband's birthday. She would frame it as reasonable, asking if they could attend both celebrations. My

husband would hesitate, reminding her that we had our own plans, but eventually, the guilt set in. We were made to feel selfish if we didn't allow the boys to attend her family's function during *our* scheduled time. We told ourselves we were doing the right thing, that giving in spared the boys from conflict. Wasn't it better to avoid a fight? If we didn't have something concrete planned, what harm could it do? What we didn't yet understand was that every small concession was teaching the boys where the real power lived, and it wasn't in our home. We told ourselves it was cooperation. We told ourselves it was maturity. The truth was, that generosity was never reciprocated. On the rare occasions when we asked for the same courtesy, whether for a family gathering or to bring the boys to an event that happened to fall on her scheduled time, it *"just wouldn't work out.*" It was always her time, always her rules.

One night stands out with painful clarity. Our oldest son had contracted impetigo. He was uncomfortable, tired, and clearly needed to rest. My husband offered to keep him overnight so he could recover in peace while she and her family attended a festival with the younger sibling and her family. However, she refused outright. Instead of allowing his dad to care for him for even just one extra night, she insisted on taking him to the festival. He was miserable the entire evening, dragged along not because it was in his best interest, but because giving his father that time would mean conceding control and giving dad more than she thought he deserved. The lesson was quiet but cruel. Their father's love could be diminished, disregarded, or even erased in the moment it was needed. She never gave us any more time than the court allowed. Even when she was out of town, she would have her parents watch the boys instead of letting them stay with us. When my husband asked, she insisted that her parents had the right to watch them on her nights, instilling the message, "When Mom is gone, you need Grandma and Grandpa, not your dad."

It felt like everything in our lives started revolving around what *she* wanted the boys to do, even when it was not her parenting time. She would deliberately sign them up for clubs, activities, and events during our days, cutting right into the little time we had to be together as a family. It wasn't about the boys having opportunities, as she would say to anyone who would listen. It was about making sure our time with them never belonged fully to us. She couldn't handle not having full autonomy over their lives. She pretended that she was trying to work with my husband, but "working with him" only meant agreeing with what she wanted, and she never really wanted a teammate.

As a teacher, I know the importance of giving children space to grow through activities, clubs, and new adventures that widen their world. I have also known the equal weight of quiet moments, of time spent together as a family, building the bonds that hold us steady. In a blended family, that balance is no longer in the hands of one parent, nor contained within a single household. It requires shared choices and shared voices. Yet

she could not bear that truth. To her, parenting was never meant to be shared between the two of them. Parenting was hers to control, hers to command, and anything less felt like loss.

As a stepparent, I never felt silenced by my husband. He values my thoughts, my instincts, my place beside him in our family, but with her, it was different. I had no standing, no authority of my own. My voice could never arrive directly, it had to be carried through my husband, softened or reframed so it might be tolerated. Every suggestion, every concern I offered became his concern, his idea, never mine. It left me in a strange in-between place, present, committed, deeply invested and yet invisible in the eyes that refused to see me. I lived in that quiet tension, knowing my love and effort were real, but my influence hidden and cast aside by her manipulation.

When my husband spoke up, when he said a certain club didn't work for our schedule, or asked to adjust the plans, she twisted it. Suddenly, my husband was being accused of "keeping them from having friends," or *"withholding them from experiences."* She would complain that we lived too far away and we were keeping them from their life in her city, the same city where we were both teachers. It was exhausting and unfair, and my husband was made out to be unreasonable for wanting to spend quality time with his kids. We actually only lived twelve miles apart, about a fifteen- to twenty-minute drive.The boys had friends in our neighborhood, in our community, and had our family to spend time with. None of that mattered. What mattered to her was control and making sure that no matter what we tried, our family time was chipped away, overpowered by her presence. She was always there, hovering at every corner, at every event she orchestrated and demanded the kids attend, to chip away at our parenting time and to drive her narrative.

We never asked her not to attend events during our parenting time, but we did expect common courtesy. Instead, our weekends were often overshadowed by her presence. At sports games, even when the boys' grandparents were visiting to watch our oldest play, she would sweep in, walk directly to where we were sitting, lift the youngest from whichever lap he was on, and carry him away, removing him from our family so he could be with her. One day, my husband finally spoke up, *"My parents are only here for the day, and it means a lot for them to have this time with the boys. You'll have them for the next four days, so I'd appreciate it if you could respect my time with them the same way I respect yours."*

Her response cut through the air like a blade, "How dare you say I can't be around ***MY*** children."

That single sentence revealed the pattern that would follow us for years. What started out as her right to be at a sporting event quickly evolved into doing whatever she

pleased, under the banner of her "*rights*" as their mother; they were "*her*" children. The irony was that we were never trying to keep the boys from her; we only asked for respect for our time, just as we respected hers. We asked to acknowledge that Dad needed his time too. She was welcome at every sports game, every school event, every child-related activity. All we wanted was the chance to share those moments with family, without her pulling the strings and overshadowing our presence. Yet, in her eyes, any boundary was an attack, and any request for fairness was "bullying." From that day forward, the word "*bully"* became her weapon of choice. For years, any disagreement, no matter how small, was shut down by her raising her voice, pointing her finger, and declaring my husband a "*bully"*. The word froze conversations in their tracks, casting my husband as the aggressor when all he had done was ask for respect or give an opinion about something that didn't align with her own.

Just four months into our marriage, I finally said aloud what I had been holding inside: something was not okay. The convenient forgetting of dates, the constant control, the way her manipulation changed his very demeanor whenever she pushed her way through. It wasn't random, and it wasn't innocent. It was deliberate. I urged him to start saving every message, every exchange, because I knew we were no longer dealing with misunderstandings, but with a deliberate, damaging pattern.

So we did. We saved Every. Single. Email. Every text and knowing our right, every conversation.*

At the time, it felt exhausting, even paranoid. However, later, those documents became our lifeline. It was evidence of what had really been happening behind the curtain of "co-parenting."

**My state is a one-party consent state. This means that under my states law, only one person involved in a conversation needs to consent to its recording. If you participate in a conversation, you can legally record it without notifying the other party. This applies to in-person, telephone, and digital conversations like video chats.*

From the Outside Looking In: *Controlling Family Time*

Here is a checklist you can use to spot when a co-parent (or any parent) is starting to control or undermine your family time:

- ☐ **Scheduling Overlap**
  - Signs the other parent is signing kids up for activities, clubs, or events that consistently fall during *your* parenting time.
    - ***What you can do:*** Keep a calendar of your parenting schedule and track overlaps. If a pattern emerges, bring it up calmly in writing, asking for balance. Suggest alternatives, like switching weeks or choosing neutral activities, so the kids don't have to miss out, but your time isn't erased.

- ☐ **Last-Minute Changes**
  - They frequently announce new plans, events, or obligations at the last minute that interfere with your scheduled time.
    - ***What you can do:*** Respond with calm firmness, "That doesn't work for us with this little notice." Don't feel pressured to say yes just because it's framed as urgent. Document these instances so the "emergencies" reveal themselves as a pattern, not exceptions.

- ☐ **One-Sided Flexibility**
  - You're expected to adjust your schedule for their plans, but they rarely (or never) agree to adjust for yours.
    - ***What you can do:*** Stop giving in every time. Flexibility is healthy, but it has to go both ways. When you say "no" kindly but firmly, you teach that boundaries are not up for negotiation. Keep a record of when you've bent, and when they haven't, it will help you if guilt sets in.

- ☐ **Guilt or Accusations**
  - If you push back, they accuse you of "keeping the kids from opportunities," "isolating them from friends," or "not supporting their interests."
  - Name calling, you are "unreasonable," "a bully," " a threat," "worthless"
    - ***What you can do:*** Refuse to argue labels. Respond only to the facts, not the insults. A simple BIFF response (Brief, Informative, Friendly, Firm) works: "I'm not available that day. The kids can attend next week." Insults lose their power when you don't engage.

- ☐ **Undermining Your Home/Community**
  - They dismiss or devalue the friendships, activities, or opportunities the kids have in your home, neighborhood, or school district.
    - ***What you can do:*** Counter quietly by continuing to build roots. Invite friends over, sign kids up for local teams, show consistency. Over time, kids see stability for

what it is, even if it's not loud or flashy.

- ☐ **Presence in *Your* Time**
  - They show up at events or activities during your parenting time and take over the attention of the children, so you never truly have space as a family.
    - ***What you can do:*** Set respectful but firm boundaries in the moment if needed. "My parents are only here for the weekend, I'd appreciate you letting them have this time." Document repeated interruptions. If it escalates, suggest neutral agreements through mediation (like separate seating at events).

- ☐ **Control Through the Children**
  - Kids are told (directly or indirectly) that they'll "miss out" if they follow your schedule, making them feel guilty for being with you.
  - Telling the children that you live too far away (even when the distance does not create a problem in parenting time and schedules)
    - ***What you can do:*** Reassure the kids that their life doesn't have to be either/or. Keep your message steady: "I love the time we have together." Don't compete with guilt and anchor them in security instead. Document these statements when they surface; over time, they reveal manipulation.

- ☐ **Isolation of Family Time**
  - Family meals, downtime, or traditions get pushed aside because their plans take priority, leaving little unstructured time together.
    - ***What you can do:*** Protect rituals, even if they're small. Pizza night, Saturday morning walks, bedtime stories become the glue of your family. Name them out loud as traditions. Kids remember the consistency more than the grand gestures.
- ☐ **Pattern Over Time**
  - It's not just once in a while; it becomes the norm that their plans dictate what happens during your parenting time.
    - ***What you can do:*** Keep written records to see the pattern clearly. When you can point to months of one-sided control, you have evidence, not just feelings. Use it to advocate for consistency, whether in conversation, mediation, or court.

Chapter 4: When Boundaries Became Battles

There comes a point in every difficult journey when you realize that love alone is not enough; you need boundaries to survive.

The next chapter of our journey was about creating those boundaries. You hear about setting healthy boundaries all the time, but truthfully, it's something we had no experience with in a coparenting environment. No one gave us any advice, there are no

handbooks, and of course we didn't have any of the knowledge we now have about parental alienation. All we had was a strong intuition that something was not right, and that the changes in the boys were impacting our household. Simply put, something needed to change. Our time, our money, and our sanity were being tested beyond measure. Setting boundaries felt like throwing pebbles into a storm. Every attempt to clarify schedules, protect family time, and our insistence on mutual respect was met with resistance. Sometimes it was icy silence; other times, overt threats of lawyers, escalating conflicts, or full-blown ***adult*** temper tantrums. Nothing we tried seemed to work. It was exhausting and demoralizing. Each effort to assert a small measure of control, over our own lives, seemed to intensify her tactics. It didn't seem to matter that we would bend over backwards to assure her, and show her how the changes we recommended were designed to make everyone's lives easier and to provide more stability to the boys. Even in the face of this, we had to keep trying, for the boys, for our sanity, and to maintain some semblance of order in a world that felt entirely dictated by her whims.

We quickly learned that setting boundaries was not a one-time act. It was a constant, grueling negotiation, often with no immediate reward, but without it, the chaos would have consumed us entirely. Her need to dictate how my husband spent time with the boys never stopped. She began insisting on "one-on-one nights," claiming it was about quality time, but what was important at that time for us was being together as a new blended family. Instead it was quite clear that her behavior was a shallowly vailed attempt to micromanage our time with the boys. She also began playing a one-sided game of one-upsmanship. It soon became evident that if we had plans to do something "special" with the boys, then she was going to top it or completely dismiss their joy over time spent with us. We did our best to not let it bother us, as our focus was on carving out family time of our own, navigating a new marriage, new co-parenting dynamics, and simply wanting the boys to see us as a unified family. But no matter what, my husband was always framed as the bad guy. If he didn't agree, it meant he "*didn't love them enough.*"

To anyone reading, you may ask why we always just gave in. I wish I had an answer. It felt like we had no choice. I don't even fully understand why we felt this way, we just did. We wanted to keep the calm, we wanted to live our lives without constant interruption and strain, so we moved through each day like shadows, present but restrained, trying to protect our family while constantly aware that the space we had, the love we offered, was being systematically undermined. Every small victory felt borrowed, every plan fragile, as if our own hearts had to bend just to keep the peace.

Once, she told my husband flat out, "*The boys don't have a relationship with you because when they were young, I spent time with them, while you were off doing other*

things." I sat there listening to her on speaker phone. She did not know I was there, but by this point in our life I always listened in to take notes and make sure we always had two accounts of what was going on. My stomach twisted. I wanted to shout, to defend him, to tell her she had no idea what she was saying, that he is an incredible father. It would not have mattered because she had no interest in the truth. She only wanted to tear him down. As a stepparent, this was one of the hardest things I'd ever faced. I could see the truth, and I felt the love he gave to the boys every single day. Regardless, I was unable to defend him as I had no direct voice in the room. My role was to support my husband and to provide guidance where I could, but most importantly my role was to remain silent as I felt I could not have a voice in the matter. Every insult, every false claim, landed in my chest like a weight I couldn't move. I was fully invested, yet powerless, caught between witnessing the injustice and knowing there was nothing I could say that would matter to her. Her belief was her own, twisted in the jealousy that she tried to hide.

One day, my oldest stepson said, *"Mom and Grandma want to know whose house I have more fun at and who I love more."* We were stunned. We told him what we knew was right. He didn't have to choose. That loving both parents was not only possible but healthy, and that there was joy to be found in both homes. It was eye-opening and heartbreaking. This wasn't just her. It was her mother, too. It became clear we weren't just dealing with a difficult co-parent. We were up against a generational pattern of control and manipulation. Her own mother, the boys' grandmother, fueled the message just as much as she did and would continue to over the years. Grandma would dictate their haircut schedule and how they cut their hair, she would make snide comments and label "their" family as the one and only, "THE family". She would perpetuate the message, that when mom isn't available you need "me, Grandma" not their own father. Their grandmother's voice weaved itself into the fabric of alienation. Soft words spoken with authority, small stories retold until they sounded like truth. Her approval may have felt like a prize they needed to earn by rejecting our family, her affection wrapped in conditions. With a gentle shake of the head or a sigh heavy with judgment, loving us, loving our family felt like betrayal. A grandparent's wisdom carries weight, her influence quietly tipped the scales, binding the boys in loyalty and reshaping memories themselves.

One of the other traits we started to notice was the story telling that our oldest at the time had started. White lies began to weave themselves into his childhood, small at first, then growing into elaborate stories about things that never happened. I remember the year he told his third-grade teacher that we celebrated Hanukkah, complete with detailed descriptions of our family traditions. For the record, both my husband and I were raised in Christian homes. Stories like that followed him for years, accounts of amusement parks he'd supposedly visited with his mom, pets they never owned,

memories that existed only in his mind. When my husband gently brought it up to his ex-wife, she turned it back on him, accusing him of calling her kids “liars”. That wasn’t it at all. Our concern wasn’t about honesty for its own sake but it was about *why* he felt the need to invent these stories. The fabrications became so frequent that we found ourselves asking regularly, “Is this a story, or is this real?” It didn’t stop in childhood, either. The habit continued into his teenage years, a thread running through his life that we could never fully untangle. These fabrications weren’t just harmless childhood imaginings, they were a symptom of something deeper. Slowly, they revealed the ways his loyalty had been divided, how the influence of alienation had seeped into his sense of truth, leaving him unsure what belonged to him and what belonged to the story someone else had written.

We lived in that perpetual loop of control, conflict and lies for two years before I became pregnant with our first child together. Despite everything, we were excited. The boys were almost four and eight when their baby brother was born, and for a brief moment, it seemed like everyone was happy for us. She even bought *me* a gift from the boys, a stuffed animal she said they had picked out. When the day finally came, and I was in the hospital holding our newborn, the reality of our situation came crashing back. We had to practically beg her to allow the boys just one hour to come with their grandma to meet their baby brother. One hour, that was all we were granted to share this once-in-a-lifetime moment as a family. I’ll never forget the story that happened in the elevator on the way up to my hospital room. My mother-in-law, proud and excited, struck up a conversation with a stranger, telling her that the boys were on their way to meet their new brother. Without hesitation, my youngest stepson corrected her: *“He’s not our brother. He’s our HALF brother.”* My mother-in-law was stunned and caught off guard. We had never used the term half brother. Before anyone could respond, the stranger knelt down, looked right at him, and said gently, *“Oh honey, there are only full brothers. You enjoy meeting your brother.”*

We didn’t realize the weight of that moment. Looking back now, it was the first sign of what was to come, the slow turning of our children against each other, the planting of seeds that our son wasn’t *really* their true brother. It was the beginning of an emotional unraveling, a quiet, steady effort to make it seem as though *our* child somehow mattered more to us than *hers*. The lines were already being drawn.

With a baby at home, life became even busier as she still tried to sign the boys up for anything and everything she could. We finally had to set a boundary. One activity per season. It wasn’t just about time, it was also about money. We were not being unreasonable; we had daycare costs, household bills, and two other children to provide for. Like most families, we lived on a budget, but in her eyes, our situation didn’t matter. Somehow, having a child together was painted as a disadvantage to the boys, as if we

were “ruining their lives” because of *his/our* child. We tried to explain, over and over, through countless emails. By that point, we had a whole “review team” for every message we sent. Both sets of parents, my sister, and close friends would read draft after draft before we would hit send, making sure our words were rational and objective. I truly believed that if we communicated calmly, clearly, and fairly, she would have to understand, but it never mattered. No matter how many people helped us word things carefully, no matter how much we tried to compromise, we were always wrong. She could not accept that we lived under a budget and had reasonable boundreis for all of our children.

I say “we,” but in her mind, it was never us. She saw everything as *him*, the abusive ex-husband who *“pushed back on everything”* she wanted for *her* kids, the kids she *“loved to the moon and back.”* Nothing was seen as a joint decision between my husband and me and nothing was negotiable.

We even tried to make it simple, if she wanted them in additional activities beyond our one-per-season boundary, she was welcome to pay for it herself. After all, neither of them paid child support through their divorce decree, they only split certain costs. Still, she refused, because it wasn’t really about the activities, it was about money that she was owed. If my husband didn’t pay for *everything* she wanted, then she was not going to spend a dime. In the end, it worked to her advantage because she could frame him as the reason the boys “weren’t allowed” to do more, because their dad wouldn’t pay for it. It is clear now that the fight over money and activities was never really about the activity itself it was about creating situations where no matter what we did, we were wrong. Every time we set a limit, she framed it as if we were denying the boys opportunities or being selfish. She made it seem like having a new baby in our family somehow hurt the boys, as though our love and attention were finite and her children were losing out. The truth is, the boys weren’t being deprived of anything unreasonable. We were trying to balance schedules, budgets, and family time, but the narrative she pushed, intentially started to seep into the kids’ minds. The rules and boundaries we set in our household were twisted into evidence that their dad “*didn’t care enough*,” that he “*made life harder,*” that he was keeping them from having fun.

That is exactly how the wedge begins to form. When one parent uses financial leverage or activity control to frame the other as uncaring or unfair, the children are put in the impossible position of choosing sides. They began to internalize that story, that one parent is somehow standing in the way of their happiness. It wasn’t just exhausting for us; it was heartbreaking to watch their trust and loyalty so clearly shift. They started telling their mom false stories, but we did not understand why they would lie. When we gently tried to call them out or ask for honesty, it backfired. She would turn it around, blaming my husband and scolding him. It left us confused and frustrated, caught

between wanting to teach our kids accountability and watching the other parent undermine that effort. Slowly, we realized that these weren't just innocent fibs, they were being shaped and reinforced by her, driving a wedge between our children and us and beginning the slow rewriting of their own memories and understanding of our family and our experiences. It was the shaping of a loyalty conflict.

<u>On the Outside Looking In:</u> Co-Parenting Control Checklist

As a stepparent, you may find yourself watching unhealthy dynamics unfold without always having the power to step in directly. This checklist is a tool to help you notice patterns and validate what you see. Sometimes you may feel like you are imagining things or being " too sensitive," but when you track behaviors over time, you start to see the bigger picture.

Use this as a guide to support your partner, protect your household boundaries, and stay grounded in reality. Share your observations calmly, write them down, and remember, your role is not to fix the other parent, but to stand steady, protect your home environment, and reinforce healthy expectations for the kids. If you are a step-parent you can support your spouse by being the third party perspective that helps them see everything clearly and not lose focus.

☐ ***Badmouthing and blame***

- *Speaks negatively about the other parent in front of the child.*
- *Implies or directly states the other parent is unsafe, selfish, or uncaring.*
- *Uses adult conflicts to justify the child's rejection ("You know how your dad/mom always acts").*

☐ ***Gatekeeping and control***

- *Controls communication or access ("They can call you later," "You don't need to go this weekend").*
- *Monitors or limits messages, phone calls, or texts between the child and the targeted parent.*
- *Uses "forgotten" schedules or last-minute excuses to disrupt visitation.*

☐ ***Emotional manipulation***

- *Makes the child feel guilty for showing love or enjoyment with the other parent.*
- *Rewards loyalty and punishes connection with the targeted parent ("I'm proud you stood up for me").*
- *Acts sad, sick, or anxious when the child spends time with the other parent.*

☐ ***Rewriting history***

- *Distorts past events to paint the other parent as unreliable or cruel.*
- *Retells stories with subtle edits that change meaning or blame.*
- *Encourages the child to reinterpret normal parenting as mistreatment or control.*

☐ ***Role reversal***

- *Treats the child as a confidant or emotional partner, sharing adult problems or grievances.*
- *Says things like "You're the only one who understands me" or "We have to stick together."*
- *Puts the child in a position to choose sides or "protect" the alienating parent.*

☐ ***Undermining the other parent's authority***

- *Tells the child they don't have to follow the other parent's rules.*
- *Contradicts discipline or household expectations to appear as the "fun" or "safe" parent.*
- *Frames the other parent's boundaries as harsh or unreasonable.*

☐ ***Creating distance and division***

- *Excludes the other parent from school updates, medical information, or important decisions.*
- *Encourages the child to keep secrets or withhold information.*
- *Pushes the child to reject the targeted parent's family, traditions, or home life.*

☐ ***False narratives and projection***

- *Accuses the other parent of behaviors they themselves are engaging in (lying, manipulating, neglecting).*

- *Uses exaggerated emotional language ("They're abusive," "You're not safe") without evidence.*
- *Positions themselves as the only trustworthy or loving parent.*

In essence:

The alienating parent's goal (conscious or not) is control. Control over the story, the child's emotions, and ultimately, the bond the child has with the other parent. Their tactics often disguise themselves as love, but their result is separation, confusion, and harm.

Chapter 5: The Mirror of Jealousy

Wrapped in all of the other experiences was the ugly face of jealousy. It began with small echoes, ones that almost seemed harmless. We joined a pool one summer, its water slides bright with laughter. We filmed the boys racing down for the first time, faces alive with joy. Her response was delight for them, but a whispered competition. *"That looks like so much fun. I'm so jealous you have a pool like that."* Soon after, she and her family joined a water park.

That became the rhythm.

We went to the Outer Banks; her family followed with their own trip to the same shore. We went camping with my husband's family who had a camper; she booked a camping trip of her own. My family's lake house became the boys' haven; several years later, her family bought one, too. According to the boys, their Grandma declared, *"We have to buy a lake house, how else will the kids learn water sports?"* as if the years of learning with us had never existed. It was petty from the outside, but to us, it was the quiet drumbeat of competition, always needing to prove her family was the center and erasing the memories of what came before with us.

Then came Italy.

The boys were young, our youngest still impulsive, living with an ADHD diagnosis. We worried about the risk of such a big trip at that age with just her and the boys in a foreign country. To take minors in a divorce out of the country there has to be consent from both custodial parents. My husband expressed his safety concerns, and recommended postponing the trip for a few years due to their age. He went on to explain that he wasn't saying "no" or challenging her ability to care for the boys, and it was nothing personal - was more about the logistics. In a few years the boys would be easier to manage and they would appreciate Italy, and all it has to offer more. Ultimately she went anyway. Her parents agreed to go with them, which was supposed to make us feel more comfortable with the trip. However, eventually the truth came out as it always does, and it revealed yet another subtle manipulation. If we did not allow the trip to happen, then the blame would be placed solely on my husband and his supposed "bullying". Now he was not only ruining the experience for their children, he was also depriving the boy's aging grandparents out of the experience too. Then, mirroring one of our exact concerns about the trip, we received the call every parent dreads: she had lost our younger son, a second grader, who stepped off a train alone while the family remained on board. Forty-five minutes later, a stranger had helped him to the police station. Had it been reversed, she would have dragged us to court. Instead, we were told to brush it off, that everything was fine. Italy marked a turning point. No longer was it just mirroring our vacations, it became escalation. Trips grew grander: Bora Bora, the American West, Banff, Norway, Sweden. Honeymoon resorts with children. Ski trips, cruises, Europe's capitals. The world itself became her stage. Yet, we were not jealous. We saw it for what it was, loneliness wrapped in spectacle. She had no partner to share these journeys, so she used the boys as "pseudo-husbands", pouring money into memories designed to bind their loyalty. Still, she accused us of indifference, throwing in my husband's face details from trips I took with my husband as a couple trying to force every trip we took as something we left the boys out of. *"You called them from a hot tub when they weren't with you on vacation,"* ignoring the fact that they had just returned from the Bahamas with her, or that she had called them plenty of times when she traveled with her friends giving them all of the details of the fun *she* was having. As much as she didn't want them on vacation with us, she wanted them to "feel" that we didn't want them with us. This was no longer about vacations. It was about belonging. She framed our family as less, our time as second-rate, our love as conditional. She made them feel that their loyalty had to be chosen, guarded, and performed. When they were on vacation with our family, she would always call midweek. The calls were not to ask how the trip was going or what the boys were enjoying. Instead, she would tell them about the next trip she was planning once they returned, or about what they were "missing" back at home. Every vacation was interrupted by her need to stay in the forefront of their minds and steady reminder that their mom was home, missing them.

By this time our youngest stepson began showing separation anxiety, we understood it was not a simple attachment. It was conditioning. He wasn't just afraid to leave his mom, he was afraid to betray her. Counselors told us, *"He's being placed in the role of man of the house."* At only seven, he carried the weight of her loneliness, her need. Her words, *"I miss you so much when you're gone,"* were chains disguised as love. This wasn't healthy bonding, it was a loyalty test. And once planted, it grew deep roots.

She had photos of her marriage to my husband and family pictures that once adorned their mantle when they were married still hung, but in the boys bedrooms. She dusted off their wedding album to show them many times throughout their childhood repeating the lines, *"Look how in love we were, I don't know why your dad is so angry now."* All reminders that their father had destroyed something precious, all designed to paint him as the villain. All was done to rewrite the story and make sure that their loyalty stayed with her. The greatest threat to her hold on the boys' came when I became pregnant with our second child. From that moment, the campaign to cast our children as outsiders and enemies intensified. Her threats escalated into real action, showing she was willing to take steps to assert control legally.

On The Outside Looking In:

- ☐ **Excessive competition** – one parent always "one-ups" the other's vacations, gifts, or experiences. A
  ➤ *What you can do:* Remind your kids that love isn't measured in money or miles. Create consistent traditions at your home that don't rely on comparison. Rituals that anchor them in stability, like family game night, Sunday pancakes, or bedtime reading.

- ☐ **Guilt-laden phrases**: *"I'm so jealous you did that"* or *"I miss you too much when you're gone"*, which make children feel selfish for enjoying time with you.
  ➤ *What you can do:* Counter quietly, without putting down the other parent. Say, *"It's okay to have fun at both homes. You're allowed to love both."* Give them permission to enjoy their full childhood.

- ☐ **Parentification**; children filling adult roles, being told they are the "man of the house" or responsible for a parent's happiness.
  ➤ *What you can do:* Release them from that weight. Tell them often: *"It's not your job to take care of me. It's my job to take care of you."* Make your home a place where they get to just

be kids.

- ☐ **Gatekeeping**: refusing to allow extra time with the other parent even when reasonable and substituting grandparents or extended family instead.
  ➤ *What you can do:* Stick to the parenting plan. Document when deviations happen, but in front of the children, stay steady and calm. They need to see one parent who values structure without drama.

- ☐ **Rewriting history**: Alienating parents often rewrite the past to create guilt or shift blame. For example, claiming the other parent caused the divorce, made poor parenting choices, or wasn't present during important moments. This confuses the child's memories and feelings, making them question what they know to be true

  ➤ *What you can do:*Respond calmly and truthfully, using short, age-appropriate explanations. Focus on facts without defending or attacking. For example, you might say: "Dad didn't leave you — he left the marriage. That's very different." Keep your message simple, consistent, and steady. Over time, truth repeated with warmth and stability helps your child rebuild trust in their own understanding of the past.

- ☐ **"Real family" language**: phrases like *"our family"* vs. *"his family"* that split a child's identity in two.
  ➤ *What you can do:* Emphasize belonging. *"You're part of all your families, and you're loved in both places."* Celebrate your child's whole identity, not just the piece that lives with you.

- ☐ **Emotional Anchoring:** emotionally inserting themselves in their time with you, reminding children where their loyalty should lie and preventing them from fully bonding or feeling at ease away from the other parent which is an intentional disruption of attachment.
  - ☐ ➤*What you can do: Set gentle but firm boundaries by agreeing on limited call times, then reassure the children afterward: "It's okay that your mom misses you, we can enjoy our time, too." This preserves connection without letting guilt or manipulation take root.*

Chapter 6: False Claims and False Realities

We were overjoyed when we learned our second son was on the way. During a family vacation, we shared the news at a small gender reveal party, and the boys' excitement was contagious. They couldn't wait to tell their mom. Later that week, when they called her with smiles and voices full of joy, her response was cold and dismissive: *"Well, I'm sure Krista is excited."* From that moment on, I began calling our son "the caveat." To her, his very existence shifted the balance in a game only she was playing. Our new baby wasn't a blessing; he was a threat. The shift came quickly. After just one night that they spent with their mom, the boys returned to us confused. Their joy had faded, replaced by words that weren't their own. *"Mom said he isn't our real brother, he's just our half-brother."* Our oldest added, *"Grandma said since I'm 12, I'll never be close to him. He's more like a cousin than a brother."* The excitement we had shared together just days before was gone, stolen in less than 24 hours.

When it came time for my scheduled C-section, we asked well in advance for the boys to spend part of that day meeting their new baby brother at the hospital, but we were told they *"already had plans"* with "*THE family."* They didn't meet their brother until nearly a week after his birth. Even after the baby had arrived, the attacks didn't stop. Medical bills became a new battleground, her share disputed endlessly, as though the baby's very existence was a financial slight against her. We would meet our deductible faster and she would have to start paying half of the medical bills sooner, which was how their shared parenting plan worked at the time. We could feel something brewing beneath the surface, but we had no idea how severe it would become.

Eight months later, it all came crashing down. We returned home from a family event to find a slip from the post office, and when I went to pick up the mail, I opened an envelope that made my hands shake. Inside were 37 separate accusations, each one outrageous, fabricated, and cruel. She had finally done what she had long threatened. She was suing us for custody and child support and trying to tarnish my husband's name and livelihood. What began as joy in welcoming a new child had been twisted into a weapon. With the arrival of those papers, the battle entered an entirely new stage.

My family, was still grieving, reeling from the loss of my father-in-law, who had fought a brief but fierce fight with pancreatic cancer. Barely three weeks after his passing, those papers arrived. She told my husband, almost with pride, *"I waited a week to file after hearing about your dad."* As though delaying her strike was some kind of mercy. My husband, already sick with grief, was forced to face her calculated blow. In the heartbreak of losing his own father, she sought to sever him from his sons. At the very

moment he needed their bond the most, she was maneuvering to erase him from their lives.

On the Outside Looking In: *How New Siblings Intensify Alienation*

When a new child is born into a blended family, it often heightens an alienating parent's fears and insecurities. The child represents permanence, a new bond that the alienating parent cannot control. Instead of welcoming the baby as an addition to the family, the alienating parent may reframe the child as a threat, fueling division by:

- ☐ **Diminishing bonds:** Using terms like *"half-sibling"* or *"not a real sibling"* to make the older children feel less connected.
- ☐ **Predicting distance:** Suggesting the siblings *"won't be close,"* planting doubt before a relationship can form.
- ☐ **Withholding access:** Controlling when or if children meet the new sibling, often turning moments of joy into moments of loss.
- ☐ **Shifting blame:** Using financial, medical, or household responsibilities around the baby as points of conflict, framing the new child as a burden.
- ☐ **Division of Love:** Suggests the targeted parent prioritizes the baby over them, loving the new child more.

Court:

After hiring our attorney and learning how to combat what we were up against, we spent two solid months compiling evidence to refute her claims. I am beyond grateful that we saved every email, every text message, and even recorded phone conversations. Those details became lifelines in navigating this storm. Not only were we able to refute each of her thirty-seven claims, but we did so with an overwhelming amount of proof: receipts, timelines, and carefully documented records and facts that couldn't be argued.

We had everything so meticulously organized digitally and in a thick binder that our law firm joked we should become paralegals. We didn't just defend ourselves, we proved, beyond doubt, that we were not the parents she painted us to be. Instead of her plan to take full custody we were assigned a guardian ad litem and the process of rewriting their shared parenting plan began. This was the attorneys' opinions of what would be best. This became the hardest season for me as a stepparent. I was completely involved in the case, yet always one step removed. I couldn't attend meetings, share my perspective, or tell the stories I had lived through. When I did sit with our attorney alongside my husband, I felt the weight of needing to stay composed, careful not to be perceived as the "emotional" wife/stepparent. There was even a year during that court case when I had to step back from attending the boys' events. She would never let us be, and my anger ran deep. I was hurt, frustrated, and disgusted by her, but for the boys' sake, I stayed away. I knew that if I confronted her, she would leverage it, to paint me as the irrational stepmom, unworthy of time with them.

Up to that point, it was the most stressful and soul-draining experience of my life, and it exposed something deeply broken in our family court system. Parents can file wild, unfounded claims, turning the courtroom into a theater for their own narratives. That's exactly what she did, spinning her version of reality, while we were left to pick up the pieces, both in our hearts and in our pockets. The days my husband spent in meetings with the guardian were long and grueling. Rather than treating them as professional discussions, his ex-wife used them as a personal confessional and an opportunity to vent her frustration over not having complete control over the boys. My husband would share the breakdown of these sessions, and I would listen to the accounts afterward, so I could be present when the law would not allow it. What I heard was not merely wrong; it was drenched in her emotions, untethered from truth. Every word was a reflection of her interpretations, her twisting of reality, her sickly vision of what she fabricated our family to look like. The phrase *"You treat your kids better than my kids"* echoed so often that the guardian ad litem finally spoke up: *"They are BOTH of YOUR kids."*

Now, looking back, I see it all clearly. Everything she accused my husband of was textbook parental alienation, down to the phrasing, the manipulation, the erasure of their bond. My only lingering question is why the guardian did not see it. I cannot say what could have been done differently, but had we known the term *Parental Alienation* then, we might have had strategies to shield our boys from the slow, insidious brainwashing that was happening right before our eyes.

She managed to drag the case out for nearly three years. It was emotionally, mentally, and even financially exhausting. In the end, we pushed for what had been missing in the original shared parenting plan: equity. We were granted a 50/50 custody visitation

schedule, a fairer division of medical expenses, and written protections that safeguarded our time. For example, she was no longer allowed to schedule vacations over Father's Day or my husband's birthday which was a habit she had used year after year to weaken Dad's role. As draining as the process was, we were relieved with the outcome. We won the battle and walked away with more than the previous shared parenting plan had given. The decree finally felt balanced, and we believed it would allow for healthier co-parenting. Whether she regretted filing the case or not, we'll never know. What we do know is that there was a shift, and her tactics evolved. They became less about legal battles and more about psychological control. She began positioning herself as the boys' "friend" rather than their parent, blurring boundaries and fostering secrecy. This shift would prove to be another fork in the road leading their emotions down a slippery slope.

On the Outside Looking In: *Protect Yourself with Documentation*

In cases of parental alienation, documentation is your strongest defense; without it, truth can be twisted beyond recognition.

- ☐ Save every email, text, and message exchange. (*Note our state is a one-party consent state, so if my husband was involved in a conversation with his ex, it was recorded and legal. This is not the case in every state.)*
- ☐ Keep a running log of dates, times, and conversations. *(As a step-parent, I helped my husband by listening to calls on speaker and taking notes so he could have the conversation take-aways, and I could jot down important details. He stopped casual conversations so we could have documentation of every event)*
- ☐ Organize your records digitally *and* in hard copy.
- ☐ Avoid emotional responses, stick to facts. Practice the "grey rock" method, short, bland answers and avoiding emotional reactions.
- ☐ **Remember: documentation isn't just proof, it's protection.**

Chapter 7: Silent Manipulation

After the court case, the ruling was clear, both parents were to act in the boys' best interest. At least, that is what the rewritten shared parenting plan said on paper. However, she continued to frame her protests as the children's voices: *"They're too afraid to ask you themselves. They want to be here, with me, at my house."* Those weren't their words, they were hers, handed down like scripts. The truth was, the boys enjoyed their time with us. Ask any friend, any family member; they thrived in our home, in the laughter of their brothers, in the simple rituals of dinners, games, and weekends together. Even though the shared parenting plan gave us equal footing, another shift began, one quieter, more dangerous. As our oldest stepped into high school, parenting on her side faded, replaced by something more enticing: friendship. Rules softened, confidences deepened, and secrets grew. It was not parenting, it was alliance, and it was invisible to us at first, hidden beneath the veil of adolescence, cloaked in the language of trust. We thought the hardest battles were behind us when the new shared parenting plan was signed. We didn't yet know that this loss of control in court would only fuel her to find a subtler weapon not bound by legal papers, but etched into the boys' hearts. There was a desperate need to prove to the boys that she loved them more, and an even deeper desire for their love to belong only to her.

Upon her request, the new shared parenting plan carried a stipulation: weekly updates. We were to account for the days the boys spent with us, a ledger of ordinary life and what they did, where they went, how they lived under our roof. She saw them every day before school on the weeks the boys were with us. At drop-off before school, and pick-up in the afternoons she had time to check in, but she demanded more. So we wrote. Carefully. Diligently. As though our words might build a bridge, or at least hold open the door to honest communication.

Once again, the bridge didn't stretched both ways.

Her updates to us became thin, vague, and almost empty. No insights, no details, only silence dressed in formality. Her reasoning was always the same: *"The boys are old enough to share those details themselves."* Any parent of teenagers knows the truth, adolescence is not a season of abundant conversations, not a time when details spill freely. Instead, we were left trying to piece together a life we could not see, fumbling in the dark, navigating waters without a compass. Meanwhile, we provided detailed chronicles of games played, meals shared, small victories, and quiet evenings, just as she'd requested. However overtime we realized that the updates we provided became something else in her hands. Rather than building bridges she used the updates to fuel

the fire she'd created. We had hoped for openness. What we received was silence. And in that silence, her control grew because we had no account of how the boys were living during the weeks they spent with her.

Once they each received a cell phone, she never truly let them go. Her words would ring through constantly on our weeks and our vacations alike,

"*I love you so much, I hope you know that,"*

"I miss you,"

"I wish I could do those things with you,"

"Guess what you are missing while you are with your dad,"

Over and over the messages dripped through the hours like a steady reminder of where their loyalty belonged. Even when she'd see them that morning and afternoon on their brief stops home before returning to our house she would text. She would involve them in decisions far in advance all through text messages, even when there was no need for immediate input. She kept the texts coming, not to connect, but to stay *present*. To remind them who was waiting for them and to make our home feel unimportant and temporary. It was affection used as a tether; soft, constant, and quietly suffocating. It turned our time against us and replaced their happy times with guilt and worry, and something that as children they couldn't really define. Our youngest son still struggles even to this day with the joy he feels when he is with us. Anytime we do something together as a family, or anything that's supposed to be fun, a look comes over his face, like a flicker of guilt, as if he's just remembered he's enjoying himself without his mom. Almost without fail, he'll bring up something he did with her, or with *her family*, as if simply being present with us is somehow wrong. He can't fully relax. He can't fully enjoy the time. Just existing with us feels, "off-limits". It's the quiet work of parental alienation. It is the shaping of a child's allegiance so subtly that even happiness brings guilt, and love becomes something they can't fully give or receive at one home.

The very things we knew were best for children like consistent boundaries, gentle correction, and lessons woven into mistakes, were recast as something darker. What we called guidance, she called control. What we meant as love, she projected as harm. For example, when our oldest dreamed of competing in an Ironman, we encouraged him to take ownership of that goal. We asked him to research what it would take participate in the event such as the training, the costs, the commitment. We also suggested that he to look into local triathlon clubs before making big purchases or quitting his high school sports teams which he said he was going to do. We saw it as teaching responsibility and follow-through; she saw it as withholding support. There

was constant undermining wapped in sympathy and both boys didn't learn what actual parenting looked like.

"I'm so sorry about the rules at your dad's house."

"I can't do anything about the rules at your dads and I am sorry."
"Don't tell him about this and I won't either."
"Your dad is so angry. I'm sorry you have to go through that."
"I'll talk to him so you don't have to deal with it."

Each phrase seemed small on its own, but together they worked like water dripping on stone, eroding trust, reshaping truth. We tried to keep the lines of communication open. When the boys stumbled, when they needed guidance, we shared. We wrote down our conversations, believing that parenting was a partnership, even in two homes. Yet what came back to us was silence or a thin reply, *"I had a high-level conversation with them."* No details. No exchange. Just a wall of vagueness. Any challenge they faced in life, she would either bulldoze or make excuses for. If they did poorly on a school assignment, it was the teacher's fault. If we held them accountable for something we asked them to do, we became the unfair parents. In time, our lessons became her leverage, and our love became her weapon. What should have been a united effort to raise children became a slow dismantling of everything we had tried to build. It was as if our understanding of adolescence that was built from years in education was a threat to her, something she needed to undo, as though we knew nothing about children at all.

On the Outside Looking In: When Court Battles End, Alienation Often Deepens

Research and lived experiences show that once a custody case concludes, some alienating parents shift strategies. If they cannot control the narrative legally, they often turn inward:

- ☐ **The "Fun Parent" Persona:** Recast themselves as the "fun parent" or "friend," undermining the other parent's authority.

- ☐ **Secrets Create Sides:** Encourage secrecy (“don’t tell OR I won’t tell your dad/mom”) to create hidden alliances.

- ☐ **Guilt by Affection:**Redefine rules so the child feels guilty for enjoying time with the other parent.

- ☐ **Subtle Manipulation:** Use quiet psychological tactics instead of overt legal ones, making alienation harder to detect and prove.

- ☐ **Emotional Tethering:** Keep the child emotionally tied through constant contact, affection, or reminders, preventing full connection with the other parent.

- ☐ **Undermined Authority:** Teach the child that one home is “safe” and the other is not, distorting trust and security.

Chapter 8: The Quiet Divide: When Adolescence Meets Alienation

The four years our oldest spent in high school marked the beginning of a quiet unraveling. At first, we told ourselves it was normal teenage resistance, the push and pull that comes with growing up. Since we both teach middle school; we know adolescence well, its turbulence and its beauty, but this felt different. What we didn’t realize then was that our parenting was being twisted and used against us. The very lessons meant to guide our kids (how to use a planner, communicate needs and wants, and take responsibility for their actions) were recast as cruelty. Our efforts to teach structure and accountability were painted as control and anger. Our expectations were simple, but when one parent undermines the other, the cloth begins to unravel. Our

morals, our values, our priorities were all diminished, all reframed as oppression. We encouraged the boys to be their own people, to explore their interests and build their friendships. When they stumbled, as all children do, we took the time to help them see the lesson in the fall. After all, life is not built on perfection, but on the courage to fall, learn, and begin again. However, lessons cannot take root when a child is taught to resent the very act of being parented. It is hard when the two homes are vastly different. One focuses on blurring the lines of parenting and friendship and the other home built on parenting with guidance and ownership. Their mother deliberately stopped being the parent and became their friend who "understood". She reframed herself as a friend who promised safety from a home she called harsh. The message was simple: staying with her was better, easier, and right. *"THE family"* was the only family who truly loved them. We didn't yet understand how subtle and powerful that shift truly was and how quietly truth can be rewritten when love is weaponized. What began as lessons in responsibility became evidence of oppression. What began as parenting became, in their eyes, proof that we were the problem, the tyrants, the villains. With each passing year, the distance deepened. Animosity took root, and resentment began to show its face. Once I reached out to their mother, asking if she had noticed our oldest's growing anger. I wondered if she saw the same and hoped we could work together to navigate teenage trials and tribulations. Her response was simple: *"I don't think there's anything wrong. He's just been rude lately, and I even had my dad and brother talk to him about it."*

She hid the truth, because the truth was of her own making. She was cultivating the anger and resentment that we mistook for typical teenage behavior. Unknowingly, I played right into her hand. So, we continued to chalk it up to adolescence.

It wasn't always bad. There were still so many good times during those high school years, family game nights, outings, cheering at sporting events, and celebrating first marathons, high school dances, first romances, etc. We celebrated achievements, glowed with pride, and basked in those fleeting moments when we felt whole; a family of six, bound by love, unaware of the storm slowly taking shape.

Communication had started to fade, little by little, over those four years. Subtle at first, then unmistakable. She began letting our oldest stay home alone at her house while she traveled for work instead of having him come to our house, where dinner would be waiting, and people who cared about him would be around. She said he didn't want to come, but by then she had already begun teaching him that staying alone was "*preparation for college*." In truth, it was another layer in the quiet campaign to paint our home as unwanted, to make him believe that solitude was safer than being with his dad or where their "*half brothers*" would disturb him. Then she started letting our younger son stay home too, only leading to more bouts of anxiety that he had possessed since elementary school, creating a gradual and subtle divide of his commitment to our family.

He began spending more time in his room to remove himself from the brothers he once couldn't get enough of and distance himself from being an active participant in our family life. The very brother that he loved, adored and was best friends with started becoming a burden.

However, we continued to be flexible, letting them stay at their mom's when they had events that made it easier to be closer to school. At the time, it felt like the reasonable thing to do, proof that we were trying to work with them, to show we cared about their schedules and comfort. Looking back, I believe every time we agreed without making up the time, it quietly reinforced a story she was already spinning. The message became that we didn't care about them, when in truth, we thought we were doing exactly the opposite. What we saw as cooperation was used as manipulation. Each small compromise chipped away at our connection. It wasn't one big event that changed everything, it was a slow erosion, almost imperceptible at first. The distance didn't just grow between homes; it grew between hearts. By the time we realized how much ground we'd lost, the narrative had already taken root, and we were being written out of a story we were still trying to be part of.

On the Outside Looking In: *The Signs We Missed*

- ☐ **Growing Disrespect:** seemed to appear overnight, the subtle eye rolls, the sarcastic tone, the dismissal of anything we said as overreaction or control.
- ☐ **Emotional Distance:** quietness that replaced laughter, a hesitance to share details about their lives, as if conversation itself had become dangerous.

- ☐ **Shifting Loyalties:** one parent became the “safe” one, the fun one, the friend. While we were cast as the problem to be escaped.
- ☐ **Rewritten History**: memories that were built together are reinterpreted, stripped of joy, and retold through a darker lens.
- ☐ **Secrecy**: the sense that conversations are being repeated elsewhere, twisted into something unrecognizable.
- ☐ **Guilt:** the feeling that no matter how patient, how kind, or how consistent we were, it was never enough to compete with the narrative being fed to them.
- ☐ **Isolation:** not just theirs, but ours. The slow silencing of a relationship that had once been full of life.

We didn’t see it then for what it was. We thought we were navigating adolescence. We thought we were giving them space to grow. In truth, we were losing them to a story someone else was writing. A story that painted love as control, guidance as punishment, and distance as freedom.

Chapter 9: The Weekend That Changed Everything

Senior and freshman year began like any other school year: busy schedules, cross-country meets to attend, soccer games to watch, and the everyday business of our lives as teachers. We helped our oldest navigate his first real heartbreak, offering advice and guidance when he felt low. We shopped for a new suit to prepare him for senior-year events and homecoming, and I had just finished helping him edit a college essay, guiding him toward a new chapter in life.

Thanksgiving came, and our ten-year-old wanted to run a 5K with his big brother. We had a wonderful weekend, filled with laughter, teamwork, and the simple joy of being together. On the Sunday before school resumed, the boys and their dad sat at the kitchen table, playing euchre, teasing and giggling; the kind of moments that make a house a home. The next day, they returned to their mom's for the week. We didn't know it yet, but that Thanksgiving weekend would be the last time we would see our oldest son. The following week, he sent a message to my husband. He was going to stay at his mom's for the foreseeable future, citing differences in his dad and his relationship. He reminded us that he was eighteen now and that we could no longer tell him what to do. We were confused. Shocked. Stunned. We reached out to him, only to be met with silence. We reached out to his mom, and she repeated the same message: he was eighteen, and we had no say over how he lived his life. The week before, he had mentioned wanting to spend a little more time at his mom's because of activities he was involved in, but never once did he suggest he was planning to abandon us. This wasn't a fleeting thought or a teenage whim. This was new. This was deliberate. This was calculated.

We went through all of December without any explanation. We had no texts, no conversation, just emptiness. A void we were left to figure out on our own. He skipped Christmas. He missed birthdays. He was gone. After the holidays, worry began to settle in. He had become involved in a new church that figuratively "swept him off his feet". It was a fast and furious devotion and relationship with God and the church community that was not the church we had been affiliated with. We did not have a problem with the church but we were starting to question anything and everything that could answer what was going on, since we were left without any answers. Hidden in his empty bed, that had not been slept in for almost a month, we found a disturbing annotation in a Bible about hating your father, mother, brother and sisters in order to be a true disciple. We thought at that moment that this could be the cause for what was happening so we reached out to his mom with our concerns about what we found. She responded that the church had nothing to do with what was happening and said that she would meet with us in person. However, she warned us that we wouldn't like what she was going to say. Desperate and unsure of what else to do, we agreed.

We met at a coffee shop. It was there she told us that our oldest had decided to leave because of how cruel our house had been, and that it had been going on for years, though we "just didn't want to see it." She also said our younger son was on the same path, that we were going to lose him too.

Looking back, I regret that meeting. We sat for three hours listening to her recount every supposed wrongdoing, from when the boys were two and four up to the present. I listened to every terrible thing she claimed we had done to her kids, and repeated over

and over how she loved them “to the moon and back.” At one point, I asked my husband to leave the coffee shop and take a walk, hoping that if I was alone, she might relent. Instead, she continued, telling me all the ways he had hurt her children, and her, over the years—at one point warning me that he is such an angry person and that I should “watch out.”

I said nothing in our defense because all I saw was a woman who had not moved on in fourteen years, someone who held on to the bitterness that caused this to happen in the first place. It was all distorted, false, and wildly shaped by anger, jealousy, and a deep need for revenge. It was the exact accusations she had written into her court case five years prior, and still, I listened. I pretended to befriend her, holding onto a fragile hope that if I let her vent, she would go home and tell our oldest that we just wanted to talk.

For example, she told me that our oldest had been devastated because we “didn’t care enough” to throw him a party after his first marathon, but the truth was far different. That morning, my husband had taken him to the marathon at six a.m., and as a family, we followed him to four stops along the route, celebrating each milestone, including the finish line. My sister, our neighbor and steadfast ally, had attended two of those stops before heading home to prepare a party for him at her house, just fifty yards from ours, because she wanted to help us, knowing we wouldn’t be back in time.

That evening, when the party began, our oldest was radiant with joy. Our whole family was there, laughter spilling over as we shared his excitement and ordered Chinese at his request. Yet, in her retelling, she had transformed that happiness into hurt. She rewrote the memory entirely: our son’s elation became bitterness, our shared celebration became neglect because the party was at my sisters house and not our own. I know now that she had never been at his first marathon because she had been away on a work trip and returned the next day. In her telling, she poured her own guilt, her jealousy, and her need for control into that moment, twisting it until it no longer resembled the truth. The joy he felt, the pride we shared, the love surrounding him was all stripped away and recast as evidence of our supposed cruelty. This, I realize, is the essence of parental alienation: a memory reshaped, a child’s experience rewritten, a mother’s absence made into blame, and in that coffee shop, listening to her, I could see the pattern repeat itself, a web of distortion spun from bitterness and envy, stretching across years of our family’s life.

So many of the events she described had never happened. She blamed us for failing to meet even the most basic needs of her children. All I did was listen, pleading with her, insisting that all we wanted was a relationship and a chance to talk with our oldest son. We left the meeting discouraged and disoriented, our heads spinning from the lies and distortions. Yet we still held a small hope that she might convince our oldest to at least

have a conversation with us. What I know now is that she never intended for that to happen. She was manipulating me, trying to turn me against my husband, and widen the divide. A discussion never happened with our oldest, and the distance only grew as the winter months dragged on.

We were devastated, hurt, confused. It consumed countless sleepless nights for me and made the hours of the day feel heavy and empty at times. This is when we began to research. I poured over articles, books, and the internet, searching for any clue, any sign of what was happening. Two months into this small, cautious search, I stumbled upon something that made my heart stop: PA (Parental Alienation). I had found what I had been looking for. I had found *us* on a search for answers. My mouth literally hit the floor. How had we never known that parental alienation was a term, an action, and something that had been happening to our family?

It's hard to describe the mix of emotions I felt. The satisfaction and devastation all at once. Relief that we finally understood what was happening, but grief at realizing that it isn't something that can be erased, fixed, or explained away by simply telling a child, "You've been manipulated; we are good people." However, giving it a name changed everything. Seeing that so many other families had experienced the same pain, that we weren't alone, gave us hope, or at least answers to desperate questions we would never have been able to identify on our own. For the first time, the chaos made sense. Knowing that was both terrifying and strangely empowering. For the first time, we could see the shape of what had been happening to our family. The pain, the distance, the confusion, it was no longer random or inexplicable. It had a name, and with that name came understanding, however painful. Understanding didn't fix it. Understanding didn't bring him back, but it gave us something we hadn't had before: clarity. With clarity came the first glimmer of hope, that maybe, just maybe, we could begin to find a way through the silence, the lies, and the heartbreak.

We missed the big moments. Senior nights. Graduation. Milestones that we will never get back. We sat on the sidelines, watching, unacknowledged, a lifetime of raising him quietly out of reach. Yet, through it all, my husband never stopped reaching out. He continued sharing his love, sending texts that often went unanswered, holding onto hope while sitting in silence, heartbroken. Eventually, we learned that our oldest had started seeing a counselor. After some thought and research, we decided to draft a handwritten letter to the counselor. We didn't want to interfere with his progress, and we respected the confidentiality between client and therapist, but we wanted the counselor to know that there might be something deeper shaping our son's conversations, something that extended beyond what appeared on the surface. We didn't know how the counselor would respond, but my husband explained that we had a well-documented case of PA and simply wanted the counselor to have the information,

in case it could help in any way. His motivation was clear: he loved his son deeply and wanted to do everything possible to support him. About 2 months after sending that letter, apporximately nine months since he left, our oldest reached out to his dad to ask if he wanted to join him in a counseling session with his counselor. It was good news, the first contact we had had in months and a chance to finally have a conversation with a third party present. The outcome of that session was emotional and positive, but it also brought to light some deeply wounded perceptions and beliefs that were not shaped by reality and could not have been his own thinking, despite what he believed. The saddest perception of all was that he believed that my husband loved our kids more than him and his brother. He assumed because his dad was married to me, that he would love our children together more. This validated us even further, as these were exact phrases his mother used over and over during the years of the court case. My husband cleared up misconceptions and felt hopeful after the session. I was happy for him too, relieved that he finally had the chance to talk and, hopefully, begin repairing their relationship.

That is where that story ends, for now. He is away at college. He answers texts from family, but only at a surface level. He has not sought out our family, asked about his brothers, or tried to be involved. In cases of parental alienation, we know we have to play the long game. Healing and reconnection cannot be forced and he will have to come to his own conclusions over time. I hope he can slowly rediscover the pieces of his childhood that belong to him: the laughter and chaos of family dinners, game nights movie nights, trips to the pool, lazy mornings with his baby brothers, visits to parks and museums, the quiet moments that were just ours. These memories, free from manipulation, are the ones that can remind him of love that was always present, even when distorted by someone else's agenda. I also hope my youngest stepson can stay grounded in reality, not let his anxiety get the best of him, and continue to feel the joy he experiences when he has good times with us, free from guilt or the weight of someone else's narrative.

For children of parental alienation, the work is often slow and internal. They must learn to separate truth from manipulation, reclaim their own experiences, and reconnect with the people who genuinely loved them. It takes time, reflection, and a safe space to remember what was real, and ultimately, it is their journey to rebuild trust, identity, and connection on their own terms.

As for me, this is why I am writing this book. I am wounded. I am hurt. I cannot move forward as easily as my husband can. He has a bond, an unconditional love, for his biological children. As the stepparent, I have always felt unseen. It is hard to fight for something I am not sure I ever truly had. I have not reached out. There was a time I was willing to meet with him, and he wanted to meet with me, but he would not respond

to my texts for weeks. Dates to meet would come and go, and with each passing day, my anger and resentment grew. Logically, I know he is a victim. I understand how this happened. Emotionally, though, it is far harder to accept. I willingly married a man with children ready to accept the responsibility of raising two children that were not mine. I was never met with love or affection, yet I accepted it anyway. Now, I am at a crossroads, unsure how to continue. My heart has bled. My exhaustion runs deep, and the morals we instilled in our children feel invisible. I still watch from the sidelines as my husband's heart aches. I see my younger stepson being pulled by invisible threads to follow in his older brother's footsteps but I keep going.

No child should ever be used as a weapon between parents. No parent should ever convince a child to turn away from someone who is willing, loving, and longing to be part of their life. The harm my stepchildren carry is quiet but immense and it lives beneath their smiles, shaping their hearts in ways they cannot yet name or understand.

This is my story and it is about endurance. I keep surviving, watching from the outside looking in and hoping that one day I will no longer feel like an outsider. Yet still, somewhere beyond the miles of hurt and silence, there is a quiet, stubborn hope. A hope that hearts can mend, that truths can be recognized, and that love; patient, persistent, and unwavering can find its way home. Until then, I keep standing, breathing, and believing that the story is not yet finished.

On the Outsid Lookin In: *Getting Through Parental Alienation*

There is no quick fix. There is no single moment where everything snaps back into place. Getting through PA is about endurance, patience, and holding onto the small threads of hope that remain, even when it feels impossible.

- ☐ **Acknowledge what is happening**: Denial only prolongs the pain. Naming it, understanding that the distance, the resentment, the false narratives are not your fault is the first step toward clarity. Knowledge is power, and recognizing PA for what it is allows you to separate your love from the lies that have been woven.

- ☐ **Manage your Expectations**: Your child may not return to you on your timeline. They may reject you, lash out, or remain distant for years. This is not a reflection of your worth or your love, it is the result of manipulation and confusion. Accepting that you cannot control their choices, only your own actions, is critical.

- ☐ **Document and Communicate Carefully:** Keep a record of interactions, maintain boundaries, and consider involving neutral third parties, counselors, therapists, or mediators, when possible. These steps are not about winning; they are about keeping the path open, showing consistency, and creating opportunities for honest conversation when the time comes.

- ☐ **Protect your Own Heart**: Parental Alienation can leave you feeling invisible, exhausted, and broken. Seek support, from your partner, friends, therapists, or support groups. Protect your mental and emotional health. You cannot pour from an empty cup, and endurance is impossible without care for yourself.

- ☐ **Hold onto Love without Expectation**: This is perhaps the hardest part. Love your child even if they reject you, even if your words are unanswered. Show up with patience, consistency, and integrity. The seeds of connection planted now may not bear fruit for years, but they are still being planted.

- ☐ **Keep Hope Alive**: PA is a long game, but truth has a way of surfacing. Time and perspective often allow children to see the love they were denied and the manipulation they endured. You may not witness the moment, but your faithfulness matters. One day, the walls built by alienation may crumble, and the love you have steadfastly maintained will have a chance to grow.

Chapter 10: Echoes of Understanding

The following reflections are **representative composites** inspired by the real emotions and patterns described by adults and children who have experienced parental alienation. They are shared to offer understanding and hope to anyone currently enduring the pain of PA. These accounts are **illustrative narratives**, not the direct words of specific individuals, and are included to help readers recognize common experiences and emotional truths.

Adult Age 24:

"I can't believe I didn't see it before. For so long, I thought I was just being loyal to Mom. I thought I was protecting her, helping her feel better. But now I realize… I was being used. I was being made to choose, to feel guilty, to hide my feelings, even about the parent I love. It makes me feel angry at first, angry that someone I trusted would twist my feelings and my memories. I feel sad, too, because I see all the moments I missed out on, all the times I doubted myself, all the love I pushed away without knowing it.

Most of all, I feel confused. I don't know who I can trust anymore. I don't want to lose my relationship with either parent, but I also don't want to feel like a pawn. I'm learning that it's not my fault, that I wasn't supposed to carry someone else's guilt or resentment. I'm just me, and I'm allowed to love both of my parents without shame.

It's hard to forgive, and it's hard to understand why it happened. But I'm starting to trust my own feelings again. I'm starting to see that my relationships don't have to be a battlefield. And even though it hurts, I know I can rebuild love and trust on my own terms."

Adult Age 28:

"I also feel wary. I question my instincts, my memories, even my own heart. Who can I trust? How do I know my feelings are really mine? But slowly, I'm learning that it's okay to reclaim my emotions. It's okay to love both of my parents without guilt. It's okay to just be me."

Adult Age 34:

"I didn't realize until much later how much I missed out on. As a child, I thought I was just being careful, loyal, doing what I was supposed to do. But now I see that so many moments with my dad—and with our family—were taken from me. Birthdays, vacations, ordinary afternoons that should have been filled with laughter… I missed them because I was being manipulated into feeling guilty for being happy or close with him."

"It makes me ache to think about all the little things I didn't get to experience, the stories I don't fully remember, the traditions I didn't get to be a part of. I see now that I wasn't choosing to miss these things—I was being pushed away, without even understanding it at the time."

"Even though it's painful to look back, I'm learning to reclaim those memories in my mind, to imagine the moments I was denied, and to hold onto the love that was always there, even if it was interrupted. I can feel the joy I was supposed to have, and I'm learning that it's never too late to nurture those connections, even as an adult."

Teenager age 13:

"I thought I was helping Mom by saying Dad was mean, but really, I was just repeating what she said. It feels weird to realize I wasn't really angry at Dad, I just thought I had to be."

Teenager age 14

"I remember pretending I didn't care about going to Dad's because Mom would get sad. I felt like I was doing the right thing, but inside, I just missed him and wanted to be honest about it."

Getting through parental alienation is not easy. It is a test of endurance, of love, and of moral courage. It is possible though and through it, you learn that your value does not depend on your children's recognition, your heart can survive the ache, and your love, patient, unwavering, and true, can outlast even the most determined attempts to erase it.

Endurance

I stayed when love was torn,
when truth was used for blame.
I spoke softly through the storm,
and never played the game.

I carried hope through years of pain,
believed in hearts unseen.
Endurance is to love again,
even when love won't convene.

Rising up when all feels lost,
holding steady, standing true
Endurance is the quiet cost
of loving what won't love you.

If you think that you are experiencing Parental Alienation here are a few names and podcasts to begin your journey of discovery:

Leading Experts:

Dr. Amy J.L. Baker

Dr. Baker is a nationally recognized expert in parental alienation, child development, and emotional abuse. She has authored or co-authored over 10 books and more than 120 academic articles on topics related to children's well-being. Her notable works include *Surviving Parental Alienation* and *Adult Children of Parental Alienation Syndrome: Breaking the Ties That Bind* My Site+1.

Dr. William Bernet

Dr. Bernet is a psychiatrist and a leading authority on parental alienation. He has edited comprehensive volumes such as *Parental Alienation: Science and Law*, which provides the latest information on clinical, research, and legal issues related to PA ccthomas.com.

Dr. Richard Warshak

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Karen Woodall

Karen Woodall is a psychotherapist specializing in parental alienation and family therapy. She co-authored *Understanding Parental Alienation*, a practical guide for parents and practitioners dealing with the effects of PA Karen Woodall: Family Separation Clinic.

Dr. J. Michael Bone

Dr. Bone is a clinical psychologist and one of the leading experts in the field of parental alienation. He has co-authored several books with Dr. Amy Baker, including *Co-Parenting with a Toxic Ex*, which provides strategies for managing high-conflict co-parenting situations

Podcasts:

Beyond The High Road of Parental Alienation: Hosted by Shelby Milford, this podcast offers healing and support for alienated parents, focusing on rebuilding lives after experiencing parental alienation. **Spotify**

Parental Alienation: From Couch to Courtroom and Beyond: Dr. Bob Evans and NAOPAS discuss the dynamics of parental alienation, providing insights into legal and mental health perspectives. **Apple Podcasts**

The Family Disappeared Podcast: This podcast shares community stories and expert insights on parental alienation, aiming to provide hope and understanding. **Parental Alienation Anonymous**

Surviving Parental Alienation: Featuring personal experiences, this podcast offers support for parents dealing with toxic ex-partners and the challenges of parental alienation. **Spotify**

Navigating Parental Alienation: Jacqueline interviews parents, mental health clinicians, and legal professionals, providing insights and strategies for reconnecting with alienated children. **Buzzsprout**

Parental Alienation and the Challenges Rejected/Targeted Parents Face: This podcast discusses the challenges faced by rejected parents, offering guidance and support for navigating the complexities of parental alienation. **Men's Resource Center**

Disclaimer: I would like to acknowledge the assistance of AI technology, including ChatGPT, for helping with writing, editing, and phrasing suggestions throughout the creation of this book. The content and final decisions are entirely my own from my life and experience of dealing with Parental Alienation as a steparent for the past 14 years.

Fifteen years into my life as a stepmother, I found myself in conversation with my nineteen-year-old stepson, now an adult in college. What he said did not come loudly, but it did not come gently either. It was measured, deliberate, edged with something I recognized immediately. It was not anger, exactly, and not cruelty. It came plainly, almost offhand, as if the thought had only just taken shape.

“I have no memory of my mom and dad together,” he said. “But I think I never had time to adjust to having a stepmom.”

The sentence landed with weight. It confirmed what a year of hard discovery had been assembling piece by piece, and it became the axis on which this story turns—a story still in motion, still unfolding, still asking to be understood.

To anyone from the outside looking in, there was no obvious conflict. There was no yelling, no shouting, no name-calling, no public bashing. The children were never exposed to firsthand scenes of hostility. From the surface, it appeared as though two co-parents managed their relationship reasonably well. But what we endured did not live in public spaces. The abuse was passive, persistent, and relentless. It unfolded quietly, behind closed doors, in the safety of texts, emails, insinuations, threats disguised as concern, and manipulation subtle enough to evade detection but powerful enough to erode trust over time.

When I first discovered the term *parental alienation*, my life flashed before my eyes. Page after page, story after story, it was not just familiar, it was us. We were not another blended family struggling through a difficult transition or clashing parenting styles. We were unmistakably living a textbook case of parental alienation. Every example mirrored our reality. All of the feelings I had buried, questioned, or second-guessed were suddenly validated. There was a moment of clarity so sharp it felt electric like I wanted scream from the rooftops. But that validation came crashing in behind it. How had we not seen it? Why had counselors, the court, or anyone failed to call it what it was? Why did it take months of self-reflection, research, and late-night podcasts to finally name what we were experiencing? Why was it only after my oldest stepson walked out the door for what was supposed to be a normal week at his mother’s, and never returned, that the truth finally surfaced?

Our journey began fifteen years ago. Fifteen years of small erasures, strained exchanges, invisible battles, and heartbreaking shifts in the children we love. Fifteen years of navigating a maze we did not know had a map. And still, our story is far from over. We live inside it every day.

That is why I am writing this book. Other parents and stepparents deserve to know that what they are feeling is not imagined. That the knot in their stomach, the sense of being forgotten, the slow severing of connections they once had with their children are not just emotions, they are real. Often, they are signs of emotional abuse, directed not only at the targeted parent but also at the children themselves. If sharing our story brings awareness to even one child, helps one family put language to what they are living, or protects one child from being weaponized, then this work matters.

This is not a story of resolution. It is a story of endurance. It is a story of truth told from one stepparent’s perspective. One taken *from the outside, looking in*. This is a story that I hope, in sharing with you, allows you to feel less alone in your own story.

we have to play the long game. Healing and reconnection cannot be forced, and he will have to come to his own conclusions over time.

I hope he can slowly rediscover the pieces of his childhood that belong to him: the laughter and chaos of family dinners, game nights, movie nights, trips to the pool, lazy mornings with his baby brothers, visits to parks and museums, the quiet moments that were just ours. These memories, free from manipulation, are the ones that can remind him of love that was always present, even when distorted by someone else's agenda.

I also hope my youngest stepson can remain grounded in reality, not allow anxiety to overtake him, and continue to experience the genuine joy he feels when he is with us: present, safe, and unburdened. I hope he never feels guilt for loving us, or pressure to carry someone else's narrative at the expense of his own lived experience. More than anything, I hope he is allowed to hold onto what is real, and to grow without being asked to question his own happiness.

For children of parental alienation, the work is often slow and internal. They must learn to separate truth from manipulation, reclaim their own experiences, and reconnect with the people who genuinely loved them. It takes time, reflection, and a safe space to remember what was real, and ultimately, it is their journey to rebuild trust, identity, and connection on their own terms.

As for me, this is why I am writing this book. I am wounded. I am hurt. I cannot move forward as easily as my husband can. He has a bond, an unconditional love, for his biological children. As the stepparent, I have always felt unseen. It is hard to fight for something I am not sure I ever truly had.

I have not reached out. There was a time I was willing to meet with him, and he wanted to meet with me, but he would not respond to my texts for weeks. Dates to meet would come and go, and with each passing day, my anger and resentment grew. Logically, I know he is a victim. I understand how this happened. Emotionally, though, it is far harder to accept. I willingly married a man with children, ready to accept the responsibility of raising two children that were not mine. I was never met with love or affection, yet I accepted it anyway.

Now I am at a crossroads, unsure how to continue. My heart has bled. My exhaustion runs deep, and the morals we instilled in our children feel invisible. I still watch from the sidelines as my husband's heart aches. I see my younger stepson being pulled by invisible threads to follow in his older brother's footsteps, but I keep going.

No child should ever be used as a weapon between parents. No parent should ever convince a child to turn away from someone who is willing, loving, and longing to be part of their life. The harm my stepchildren carry is quiet but immense, and it lives beneath their smiles, shaping their hearts in ways they cannot yet name or understand.

This is my story, and it is about endurance. I keep surviving, watching from the outside looking in, and hoping that one day I will no longer feel like an outsider. Yet still, somewhere beyond the miles of hurt and silence, there is a quiet, stubborn hope. A hope that hearts can mend, that truths can be recognized, and that love, patient, persistent, and unwavering, can find its way home.

Until then, I keep standing, breathing, and believing that the story is not yet finished.

Desperate and unsure of what else to do, we agreed.

We met at a coffee shop. It was there she told us that our oldest had decided to leave because of how cruel our house had been and that it had been going on for years, though we “just didn’t want to see it.” She also said our younger son was on the same path, that we were going to lose him, too.

Looking back, I regret that meeting. We sat for three hours listening to her recount every supposed wrongdoing, from when the boys were two and four up to the present. I listened to every terrible thing she claimed we had done to *her* kids and heard her repeat over and over how she loved them “to the moon and back.”

At one point, I asked my husband to leave the coffee shop and take a walk, hoping that if I was alone, she might relent. Instead, she continued, telling me all the ways he had hurt *her* children and her over the years, even warning me that he was such an angry person and that I should “watch out.”

I said nothing in our defense because all I saw was a woman who had not moved on in fifteen years, someone who held on to the bitterness that caused this to happen in the first place. It was all distorted, false, and wildly shaped by anger, jealousy, and a deep need for revenge.

It was the exact set of accusations she had written into her court case five years prior, and still, I listened. I pretended to befriend her, holding onto a fragile hope that if I let her vent, she would go home and tell our oldest that we just wanted to talk.

For example, she told me that our oldest had been devastated because we “didn’t care enough” to throw him a party after his first marathon, but the truth was far different. That morning, my husband had taken him to the marathon at six a.m., and as a family, we followed him to four stops along the route, celebrating each milestone, including the finish line. My sister, our direct neighbor and steadfast ally, had attended two of those stops before heading home to prepare a party for him at her house, just fifty yards from ours, because she wanted to help us, knowing we wouldn’t be back in time to get everything ready from being at the marathon all day.

That evening, when the party began, our oldest was radiant with joy. Our whole family was there, laughter spilling over as we shared his excitement and ordered Chinese food at his request.

Yet, in her retelling, she transformed that happiness into hurt. She rewrote the memory entirely: our son’s elation became bitterness, our shared celebration became neglect because the celebration was held at my sister’s house instead of our own. We didn’t “care” about him enough to have the party at *our* house.

I know now that she had not been at his first marathon because she had been away on a work trip and returned the next day. In her telling, she poured her own guilt, her jealousy, and her need for control into that moment, twisting it until it no longer resembled the truth.

The joy he felt, the pride we shared, and the love surrounding him were all stripped away and recast as evidence of our supposed cruelty.

This, I realize, is the essence of parental alienation: a memory reshaped, a child’s experience rewritten, a mother’s absence made into blame. And in that coffee shop, listening to her, I could see the pattern repeat itself, a web of distortion spun from bitterness and envy, stretching across years of our family’s life.

So many of the events she described had never happened. She blamed us for failing to meet even the most basic needs of *her* children. All I did was listen, pleading with her, insisting that all we wanted was a relationship and a chance to talk with our oldest son. We left the meeting discouraged and disoriented, our heads spinning from the lies and distortions. Yet we still held a small hope that she might convince our oldest to at least have a conversation with us. What I know now is that she never intended for that to happen. She was manipulating me, trying to turn me against my husband and widen the divide.

A discussion never happened with our oldest, and the distance only grew as the winter months dragged on.

We were devastated, hurt, and confused. It consumed countless sleepless nights for me and made the hours of the day feel heavy and empty at times.

This is when we began to research. I poured over articles, books, and the internet, searching for any clue, any sign of what was happening. Two months into this small, cautious search, I stumbled upon something that made my heart stop: PA (Parental Alienation).

I had found what I had been looking for.

I found *us.*

My mouth literally hit the floor. How had we never known that parental alienation was a term, an action, and something that had been happening to our family?

It is hard to describe the mix of emotions I felt. The satisfaction and devastation all at once. Relief that we finally understood what was happening, but grief at realizing that it isn’t something that can be erased, fixed, or explained away by simply telling a child, “You’ve been manipulated; we are good people.”

However, giving it a name changed everything. Seeing that so many other families had experienced the same pain, that we weren’t alone, gave us hope, or at least answers to desperate questions we would never have been able to identify on our own.

For the first time, the chaos made sense. Knowing that was both terrifying and strangely empowering. For the first time, we could see the shape of what had been happening to our family. The pain, the distance, the confusion, it was no longer random or inexplicable. It had a name, and with that name came understanding, however painful.

Understanding didn't fix it. Understanding didn't bring him back. But it gave us something we hadn't had before: clarity. With clarity came the first glimmer of hope that maybe, just maybe, we could begin to find a way through the silence, the lies, and the heartbreak.

We missed the big moments. Senior nights. Graduation. Milestones that we will never get back. We sat on the sidelines, watching, unacknowledged, a lifetime of raising him quietly out of reach. Yet through it all, my husband never stopped reaching out. He continued sharing his love, sending texts that often went unanswered, holding onto hope while sitting in silence, heartbroken. Eventually, we learned that our oldest had started seeing a counselor. After some thought and research, we decided to draft a handwritten letter to the counselor. We didn't want to interfere with his progress, and we respected the confidentiality between client and therapist, but we wanted the counselor to know that there might be something deeper shaping our son's conversations, something that extended beyond what appeared on the surface.

We didn't know how the counselor would respond, but my husband explained that we had a well-documented case of PA and simply wanted the counselor to have the information in case it could help in any way. His motivation was clear: he loved his son deeply and wanted to do everything possible to support him.

About two months after sending that letter, approximately nine months since he left, our oldest reached out to his dad to ask if he wanted to join him in a counseling session with his counselor. It was good news, the first contact we had had in months, and a chance to finally have a conversation with a third party present.

The outcome of that session was emotional and positive, but it also brought to light some deeply wounded perceptions and beliefs that were not shaped by reality and could not have been his own thinking, despite what he believed.

The saddest perception of all was that he believed my husband loved our kids more than him and his brother. He assumed that because his dad was married to me that he would love our children together more. This validated us even further, as these were the exact phrases his mother had used over and over during the years of the court case.

My husband cleared up misconceptions and felt hopeful after the session. I was happy for him too, relieved that he finally had the chance to talk and, hopefully, begin repairing their relationship.

He is away at college. He answers texts from my husband and my mother-in-law, but only at a surface level. He has not sought out our family, asked about his brothers, or tried to be involved.

In cases of parental alienation, we know we have to play the long game. Healing and reconnection cannot be forced, and he will have to come to his own conclusions over time.

I hope he can slowly rediscover the pieces of his childhood that belong to him: the laughter and chaos of family dinners, game nights, movie nights, trips to the pool, lazy mornings with his baby brothers, visits to parks and museums, the quiet moments that were just ours. These memories, free from manipulation, are the ones that can remind him of love that was always present, even when distorted by someone else's agenda.

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day I will no longer feel like an outsider. Yet still, somewhere beyond the miles of hurt and silence, there is a quiet, stubborn hope. A hope that hearts can mend, that truths can be recognized, and that love, patient, persistent, and unwavering, can find its way home.

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He deserves to have a relationship with both parents. He wants to try, but it is recognizable that a part of us exist in his mind as villains, marked and tainted. He seems to believe that our entire existence throughout his childhood was centered on making his life harder. I told him that every decision we made was intended to create the best version of himself, so that when he reached adulthood he would have the tools to thrive. But logic cannot dismantle a narrative reinforced for fifteen years. Each explanation was met with another accusation, as though the story had to keep expanding to survive. His mother has positioned herself as the victim for most of his life, and now he carries that same lens. I left that conversation wishing I had asked him what we did right or what good memories he still holds. That question will have to wait, if he ever allows space for it in the future.

We ended the conversation with the door open. We told him he could ask questions anytime and that we are willing to talk and work through whatever he needs. We were also honest. We will not beg or chase him into a relationship. He knows where we are and he knows he belongs in our family. The invitation stands. Time will tell what comes next. The step forward was small, but the damage runs deep, and his mother continues to deepen the wound every chance she can. Still, it was a step and in families shaped by alienation, even small steps matter.

One day I will give him this book. Not today. Right now belongs to healing and quiet presence. This stage is about showing him stability, truth, and love without conditions. Maybe it will be enough. It may not undo the years shaped by alienation but it gives us something to build on, one conversation, one visit, and one fragile step at a time.

If there is any justice for families fractured by manipulation and silence, then I can only hope that the truth will find its way home, piece by piece.

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“I have no memory of my mom and dad together,” he said. “But I think I never had time to adjust to having a stepmom.”

The sentence landed with weight. It confirmed what a year of hard discovery had been assembling piece by piece, and it became the axis on which this story turns. A story still in motion, still unfolding, still asking to be understood.

To anyone from the outside looking in, there was no obvious conflict. There was no yelling, no shouting, no name-calling, no public bashing. The children were never exposed to firsthand scenes of hostility. From the surface, it appeared as though two co-parents managed their relationship reasonably well and a friendly stepparent that was involved. But what we endured did not live in public spaces. The abuse was passive, persistent, and relentless. It unfolded quietly, behind closed doors, in the safety of texts, emails, insinuations, threats disguised as concern, and manipulation subtle enough to evade detection but powerful enough to erode trust over time.

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That is why I am writing this book. Other parents and stepparents deserve to know that what they are feeling is not imagined. That the knot in their stomach, the sense of being forgotten, the slow severing of connections they once had with their children are not just emotions, they are real. Often, they are signs of emotional abuse, directed not only at the targeted parent but also at the children themselves. If sharing our story brings awareness to even one child, helps one family put language to what they are living, or protects one child from being weaponized, then this work matters.

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My wish for him is that he continues to thrive when he comes to our house. That he keeps valuing the relationships he has with his brothers, the jokes, the laughter, and the ease he feels here, and that he knows this home will always be a consistent, steady place for him.

I hope he does not feel bound to follow in his older brother's footsteps, but instead learns to speak up, to question what he has been told, and to use his own rational thinking to evaluate what he already knows, deep down, to be true. Most of all, I hope he understands that he is allowed to love fully, to have fun freely, and to experience all sides of his family without guilt or hesitation.

Both of my stepchildren have been shaped by this. They were not given the space to develop independence or to work through challenges without interference from their mother, despite how much we tried to encourage those skills. The effects are not loud or immediate. They are slow, subtle, and difficult to witness, like watching a foundation erode one small, almost invisible crack at a time. In our home, we fight that erosion deliberately. We create consistency. We encourage independence. We leave room for questions, mistakes, and growth. Alongside us, whether he realizes it or not, my younger stepson is fighting too, simply by continuing to thrive here. By valuing his relationships with his brothers. By laughing easily. By settling into the sense of safety and steadiness this house offers him. My hope is that he always knows this will be a place he can return without confusion.

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1. We were never angry in our home, not in the way the word suggests. There was frustration at times, concern, exhaustion, even urgency. But "anger" was the word that took hold. It was simpler. Louder. Easier to repeat. Once it was spoken often enough, it began to stand in for everything else.

2. “Angry” was the word that came to define our home, though it never truly described it. It became a shorthand label applied to moments that were far more complex. Over time, the word stopped describing behavior and started shaping belief.

Even after that meeting, she maintained strict control over how and when my husband was allowed to communicate. She instructed him to text our oldest only once a week, and only with a brief message saying he was thinking of him. We complied, believing that cooperation might reduce conflict and support reconnection. My husband followed her instructions exactly, holding onto the hope that she was reinforcing our efforts privately. After three months of unanswered messages, it became clear this was not about protecting boundaries or reducing stress. It was about restricting access. With that realization and a growing understanding of parental alienation, we stopped following her directives.